4. A role-action involving definite political orientation embedded in a particular type of political culture; or

5. A direct relation of the individual citizens to the formal government.

DETERMINANTS

Indian society is highly diversified in nature and composition. Hence, voting behaviour in India is determined or influenced by multiple factors. These several factors can be divided, into two broad categories, namely, socio–economic factors and political factors. These are explained below:

1. Caste: Caste is an important factor influencing the behaviour of voters. Politicisation of caste and casteism in politics has been a remarkable feature of Indian politics. Rajni Kothari, an eminent political analyst, said "Indian politics is casteist, and caste is politicised". While formulating their election strategies, the political parties always take into account the factor of caste.

Paul Brass has very-well explained the role of caste factor in the Indian voting behaviour in the following way: "At the local level, in the country side, by far the most important factor in voting behaviour remains caste solidarity. Large and important castes in a constituency tend to back either a respected member of their caste or a political party with whom their caste members identify.[5]

2. Religion: Religion is another significant factor which influences the electoral behaviour. Political parties indulge in communal propaganda and exploit the religious sentiments of the voters. The existence of various communal parties has further added to the politicisation of religion. Despite India being a secular nation, no political party ignores the influence of religion in electoral politics.

3. Language: Linguistic considerations of the people influence their voting behaviour. During elections, the political parties arouse the linguistic feelings of the people and try to influence their decision-making. The re-organisation of states (in 1956 and later) on language basis clearly reflects the significance of language factor in Indian politics. The rise of some political parties like DMK in Tamil Nadu and TDP in Andhra Pradesh can be attributed to the linguism.

4. Region: Regionalism and sub-regionalism play an important role in voting behaviour. These parochial feelings of sub-nationalism led to the emergence and perpetuation of regional parties in various states. These regional parties appeal to the electorate on the ground of regional identities and regional sentiments. Sometimes, the secessionist parties call for the boycott of elections.

5. Personality: The charismatic[6] personality of the party leader plays an important role in electoral behaviour. Thus, the towering image of Jawaharlal Nehru, Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi, Jay Prakash Narayan, Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Narendra Modi has significantly influenced the electorate to vote in favour of their parties. Similarly, at the state level also, the charismatic personality of the regional party leader has been a significant factor of popular support in the elections.

6. Money: The role of money factor cannot be overlooked in explaining the voting behaviour. Despite the limitations on the election expenditures, crores of rupees are spent on elections. The voters seek money or liquor or goods in return for their votes. In other words, 'votes' are freely exchanged for 'notes'. However, money can influence the decisions of the voters only in the normal circumstances and not in a wave election.